



THE NECKLACE

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Guy de Maupassant

About the Author:

Guy de Maupassant (1850-1893) was a famous French short story writer known for realistic stories, sharp observation, irony, and surprise endings. His stories often expose human weaknesses such as pride, vanity, greed, false social ambition, and dissatisfaction. In **“The Necklace”**, he uses a simple incident in middle-class life to show how one mistake, caused by vanity and dishonesty, can destroy years of happiness.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- Vanity and false pride can lead to suffering and ruin.
- Dissatisfaction with one's life can destroy peace and gratitude.
- Appearance and social status are often deceptive and temporary.
- Dishonesty and fear of truth can make a small problem much bigger.

- The irony of life: what looks precious may be worthless, and what looks small may change a whole life.

Values:

- Be content with what you have instead of comparing yourself with richer people.
- Choose honesty early; hiding the truth can create bigger damage later.
- Do not judge life by clothes, jewellery, parties, and social show.
- Respect hard work and simple living more than temporary glamour.
- A wise person values character, truth, and peace over external appearance.

2. Characters

- **Matilda Loisel:** The main character. She is beautiful but unhappy, vain, and dissatisfied with her modest life. Her desire for luxury leads to the central tragedy of the story.
- **Monsieur Loisel:** Matilda's husband. He is a simple, loving, and practical clerk who tries to make his wife happy, even by sacrificing his own comfort.
- **Madame Forestier:** Matilda's rich friend who lends her the necklace. She later reveals the shocking truth that the necklace was only an imitation.
- **The Minister and Party Guests:** Background characters who represent the upper-class social world that Matilda dreams of entering.
- **The Jewellers:** They help the Loisels search for a replacement necklace and become part of the financial burden that changes their lives.

3. Detailed Summary

“**The Necklace**” is a powerful story about vanity, false pride, and the cost of hiding the truth. It centres on **Matilda Loisel**, a beautiful young woman married to a simple clerk, **Monsieur Loisel**. Though she has a decent home and a caring husband, she is unhappy because she believes she deserves luxury and admiration.

Matilda constantly dreams of grand houses, rich dresses, costly jewellery, and a higher social life. Her real problem is comparison: she sees ordinary life as an insult and fails to value the comfort and love already present in her home.

One day, Monsieur Loisel brings an invitation to a grand party at the Minister's residence. He expects Matilda to be excited, but she becomes upset because she has no suitable dress. To make her happy, he gives her the money he had saved for himself, showing his sacrifice and affection.

Even after buying a dress, Matilda feels incomplete without jewellery. Her husband suggests borrowing some from her wealthy friend, **Madame Forestier**. Matilda chooses a beautiful diamond necklace, which makes her feel elegant and worthy of the rich society she has always imagined.

At the party, Matilda becomes the centre of attention. She dances, receives admiration, and enjoys the happiest night of her life. But this short moment of glamour soon turns into disaster when she returns home and discovers that the necklace is missing.

Matilda and her husband search everywhere but fail to find it. Instead of telling Madame Forestier the truth, they decide to hide the loss. This wrong decision becomes the turning point of their lives because their fear of shame creates a much bigger punishment.

The Loisels buy an identical replacement necklace at a huge cost. Monsieur Loisel uses his savings, borrows money, and takes heavy debts. They return the necklace to Madame Forestier, who does not notice the difference.

For the next ten years, the Loisels live in hardship to repay the debt. They move to a cheaper house, remove their servant, do all the work themselves, and sacrifice comfort, beauty, and peace. Matilda becomes rough and aged, while her husband works tirelessly to pay what they owe.

After the debt is finally cleared, Matilda meets Madame Forestier and reveals the truth with pride in her sacrifice. Madame Forestier is shocked and tells her that the original necklace was only an imitation and worth very little.

The ending is deeply ironic. Matilda and her husband lost ten years of life for a fake necklace. If they had told the truth at the beginning, the tragedy could have been avoided. The necklace symbolises false beauty, social illusion, and the danger of valuing appearance more than truth.

4. Key Points

- **Matilda Loisel** is unhappy because she desires luxury beyond her social position.
- **Monsieur Loisel** sacrifices his saved money so that Matilda can buy a dress for the party.
- **Madame Forestier** lends Matilda a necklace that appears costly and beautiful.
- Matilda enjoys one glamorous night at the party but later loses the necklace.
- The Loisels hide the truth and buy an expensive replacement necklace by borrowing money.
- They spend ten difficult years repaying the debt and lose their comfort, beauty, and peace.
- At the end, Madame Forestier reveals that the original necklace was imitation, not real diamonds.
- The story ends with irony and teaches the danger of vanity and dishonesty.

5. Moral

- Be satisfied with what you have; comparison creates unnecessary sorrow.
- Vanity and false pride can destroy years of peace and happiness.
- Honesty at the right time can save a person from bigger suffering later.
- A simple life with truth is better than a glamorous life built on appearance.
- Do not measure people by clothes, ornaments, wealth, or social status.
- Small mistakes become disasters when we hide them instead of facing them.
- True richness is peace, honesty, gratitude, and self-respect.

Score 100/100 with AbiLearn! - Best of Luck for your Board Exams!